



The Peace of the Pyrenees in 1659 saw Louis XIV of France (center left) meet Philip IV of Spain to ratify the treaty that ended Franco-Spanish conflict.



Swedish Empire
The Swedish Empire reached its peak in 1658 in the reign of Charles X, following the Treaty of Roskilde. However, the need to defend its new territories forced it into a series of unsustainably expensive wars.

LOUIS XIV (1638–1715)

Louis XIV, known as *Le Roi Soleil* (Sun King), had a greater impact on France than any other monarch. Determined to be the absolute ruler of his nobles and his country, he centralized the state, fought numerous wars, and also encouraged culture. By his later reign, France had expanded its territory and was the leading nation in Europe, much admired and imitated.



resolved this dilemma. It was left to his successor, the rather less shrewd James II, to provoke the crisis that would later definitively propel England into a **unique parliamentary revolution** (see 1688).

The famous **English diarist Samuel Pepys** (1633–1703) began putting his daily thoughts on paper in 1660. Pepys was a high-ranking naval official, and his diary, which he kept until 1669 but which was not published until the 19th century, provided one of the most valuable sources of information on **life during the English Restoration**.

The death of Cardinal Mazarin (see 1648) in 1661 began the **personal rule of the 22-year-old Louis XIV**. He would remain on the French throne for a further 53 years. A childhood in which France was divided made him aware of the need to develop a style of personal assertiveness and grandeur. This was to impress on the French elites that they were part of his great project for French glory and **preeminence in Europe**. United under a ruler who recognized their privileges and status, French nobles and officials supported a series of wars to assert this position. However, these wars would bring France to the brink of disaster and pauperize most of its population. Yet the **cultural impact** of Louis' rule remained; no other European country would approach France in the second half of the 17th century for such a projection of national preeminence.

campaigns were launched against the Sikhs and the Marathas, **exhausted the country's treasuries** and highlighted the internal flaws of his vast empire. By his death in 1707, it was visibly in decline.

Near Dunkirk, in northeastern France, on June 14, 1658 a combined Anglo-French force defeated the Spanish. This was the last decisive conflict of the **Franco-Spanish War** that had begun in 1635, and as such the last battle of the Thirty Years' War. It was also the last confrontation of the **Anglo-Spanish War**, which had begun in 1654. For the French, the imperative, as ever, was dominance in Europe; for the English, to steal whatever advantage, commercial or territorial, they could over Spain, hence the **pragmatic alliance** between Oliver Cromwell's Puritan England with Louis XIV's Catholic France.

The year 1659 marked the start of one of the most remarkable developments of the **scientific revolution** in Europe with the beginning of what is now known as the **Central England Temperature**, or CET, record. It was a scientific experiment on an unprecedented scale, an attempt to measure temperatures almost nationally, but in reality within a triangle bounded in the north by Manchester, the east by London, and in the west by Bristol. Today, it constitutes the oldest continuous **measurement of temperatures** in the world. It had a precedent of sorts in 1657 in Italy, the Accademia del Cimento (Academy of Experiment) in Florence instituting what has been called the "world's first weather observation network." If Europe's scientific revolution depended on **accurate observation** and measurement, the CET was a crucial forerunner.

The **Peace of the Pyrenees** in November 1659 ended the enduring Franco-Spanish conflict in Europe. France was now **Europe's major power**, and Spain, its New World revenues diminishing, its internal tensions multiplying, and its support from

£400 THE VALUE OF THE EARLIEST- KNOWN CHECK

Austria curtailed, was slowly subsiding. The change roused those states able to confront an assertive France to do just that, putting France on a collision course with the other **emerging powers in Europe**: England, the Dutch, and Habsburg Austria.

"... **BLESSED GOD... IT WAS THE LORD'S DOING.**" With these words diarist John Evelyn recorded the overwhelming reception accorded Charles II (1630–85) in London in May 1660 on his **restoration as king of England**. By any measure, Charles's restoration was a triumphant vindication of the principles of kingship, as well as of the contradictory limitations of Oliver Cromwell's republican experiment. Charles II swept back to his throne on a wave of popular sentiment. Worldly, knowing, and, at heart, lazy, Charles was always **ready to compromise** with his parliamentary opponents. His charm was legendary. That said, his weakness for pleasure-seeking combined with his instinctive sympathy for Catholicism, especially when funded by Louis XIV in France, highlighted a **still unresolved political crisis**. Charles, by turns vengeful and forgiving, never

